BARCELONA, SPAIN

Museu Nacional d’Art de Catalunya: Masterpieces

Twenty modern paintings in which daily surroundings matter as much as the people.



The bicycle at the beginning of this selection offers a useful way into it. Casas and Romeu are recognisable individuals, but their shared effort, bent backs and unceremonious transport do much of the portraiture. Elsewhere, a garden almost conceals its owner; a café table separates a sitter from the spectator; a railway briefly interrupts a valley. These paintings give people a place in the world without always making them its centre.

This is a selection from the museum’s modern holdings, not a survey of the entire MNAC. Its emphasis is on the spaces between public life and private occupation: cafés, courtyards, domestic rooms, fields and the paths leading away from them.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/national-art-catalonia

The selection · 20

1. Ramon Casas and Pere Romeu on a Tandem
   Ramon Casas · 1897
2. Mr Quer's Garden
   Santiago Rusiñol · 1889
3. Romance
   Santiago Rusiñol · 1894
4. Basque Celebration at El Antiguo, San Sebastián
   Darío de Regoyos · 1888
5. The Blue Courtyard
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6. Cala Forn
   Joaquim Sunyer · 1917
7. Chlorosis
   Sebastià Junyent Sans · c. 1899
8. Plein Air
   Ramon Casas · c. 1890–1891
9. Consuelo
   Isidre Nonell · 1905
10. Dream
    Joan Brull · 1897
11. Flores
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12. Good Friday at Dawn in Orduña
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13. The Holy Family
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14. Entrance to the Moulin de la Galette Park
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15. Landscape
    Francesc Torrescassana Sallarés · 1864
16. Living Room Interior
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17. The Waterwheel at Onclet
    Joaquín Mir Trinxet · 1922
18. Landscape
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19. Pancorbo: A Passing Train
    Darío de Regoyos · 1901
20. Peñalara
    Jaume Morera i Galícia · c. 1891

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Ramon Casas and Pere Romeu on a Tandem

Ramon Casas

1897 · Museu Nacional d'Art de Catalunya



Ramon Casas. Ramon Casas and Pere Romeu on a Tandem. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Casas painted this double portrait for the beer hall Els Quatre Gats, where it hung as part of the interior. That setting helps explain its poster-like directness. The tandem locks the two riders into one comic silhouette; a formal portrait would separate their identities, whereas this one depends on their having to pedal together.

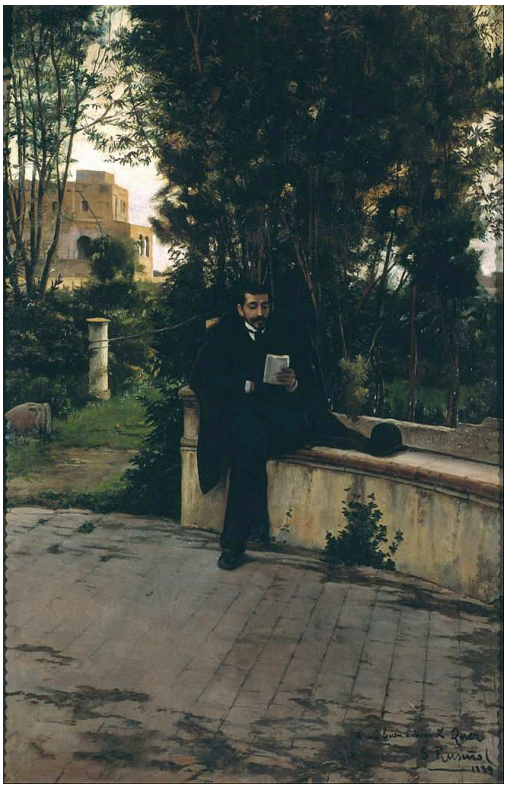
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 069806-000

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Mr Quer's Garden

Santiago Rusiñol

1889 · Oil on canvas · Museu Nacional d'Art de Catalunya



Santiago Rusiñol. Mr.Quer in the Garden. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/santiago-rusinol/senyor-quer-in-the-garden-1889 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The garden is too substantial to serve as a neutral portrait background. Its paths and shade give the small, dark figure somewhere to belong, while keeping his face secondary. Try reversing the usual priority of portraiture: instead of asking what the man looks like, consider how much of his presence is carried by the place.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Romance

Santiago Rusiñol

1894 · Museu Nacional d'Art de Catalunya



Santiago Rusiñol. A Romance. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The instrument occupies the space between the woman in red and the standing man. It establishes something they share without explaining their private relationship. Her position at the keyboard and his near the music give each a different part in the scene. The title's suggestion of romance remains less definite than the visible act of making music.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 011422-000

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Basque Celebration at El Antiguo, San Sebastián

Darío de Regoyos

1888 · Museu Nacional d'Art de Catalunya



Darío de Regoyos. Basque Celebration (dance at El Antiguo, San Sebastián). Image credit: Darío de Regoyos. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The dancers form a curved chain across the ground, a temporary boundary within a much larger view of bay and hills. Musicians and bystanders belong to its edges rather than a single crowded centre. The arrangement gives the celebration room to spread, retaining the difference between taking part and watching.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 065614-000

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The Blue Courtyard

Santiago Rusiñol

1913 · Museu Nacional d’Art de Catalunya



Santiago Rusinol. Blue Courtyard. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

Here the strongest garden colour belongs to the walls. The blue enclosure sets off the pots and plants, while a narrow passage offers a glimpse of a different, brighter space. Depth is rationed: most of the courtyard holds the eye near the surface, and the opening becomes especially effective because there are so few ways out.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 145243-000

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Cala Forn

Joaquim Sunyer

1917 · Museu Nacional d'Art de Catalunya



Joaquim Sunyer. Cala Forn. Image credit: Joaquim Sunyer. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The foreground women, children and baskets have a rounded solidity echoed by the coastal setting. They form a carefully assembled group rather than an incidental crowd. That order does not remove the ordinary subject, but it changes its emphasis: the bodies are considered in relation to the tree, village and bay as well as to one another.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 011004-000

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Chlorosis

Sebastià Junyent Sans

c. 1899 · Museu Nacional d’Art de Catalunya



Sebastià Junyent Sans. Chlorosis. Image credit: Didier Descouens. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The open book establishes an activity, but the reclining posture suspends it. A lowered head and the pressure of the sofa give the scene a bodily specificity that the medical title might otherwise overwhelm. The title records a historical way of naming the subject; a painted posture is not enough to diagnose the woman.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 038927-000

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Plein Air

Ramon Casas

c. 1890–1891 · Museu Nacional d’Art de Catalunya



Ramon Casas. Plein air. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The café’s pale tables occupy more space than its apparent social activity. Around the seated woman, the gaps become conspicuous. This is useful to compare with the crowded expectation raised by the café setting: the picture gives leisure a place, yet leaves much of that place unoccupied and its possible conversations unstated.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 010901-000

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Consuelo

Isidre Nonell

1905 · Museu Nacional d’Art de Catalunya



Isidre Nonell. Consuelo. Image credit: Isidre Nonell. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Consuelo’s face is largely withheld. The red skirt, bent body, dark hair and enclosing cloth supply the portrait’s main divisions, so that posture carries information usually sought in an expression. The result need not be assigned a particular sadness. What can be established is the weight of the seated figure and the way she folds inward.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 069008-000

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Dream

Joan Brull

1897 · Museu Nacional d’Art de Catalunya



Joan Brull. Dream. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/joan-brull/ensueno-1897 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The pale figure is less sharply separated from the bank and water than the seated figures in Casas or Nonell. Hanging branches and softened distances make the setting difficult to resolve into distinct stages. The dream of the title is therefore supported by the manner of seeing: edges remain uncertain even where a recognisable landscape persists.

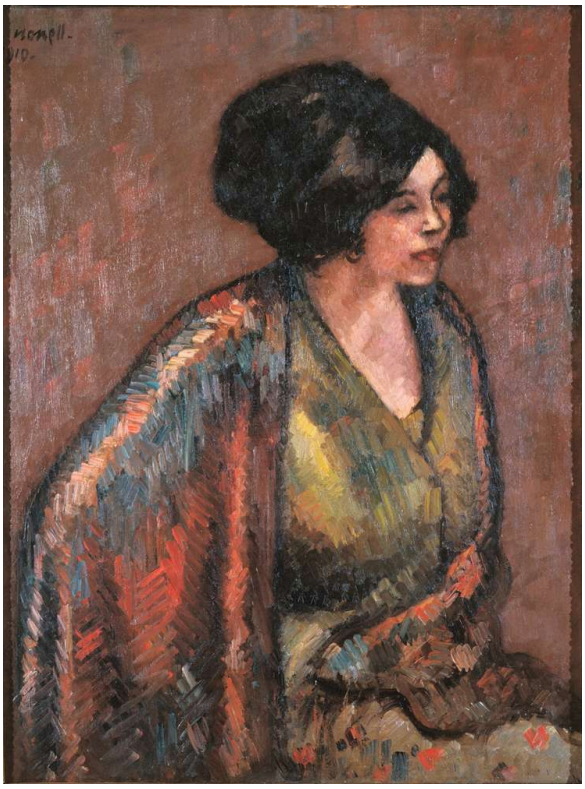
Object source · Open artwork

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Flores

Isidre Nonell

1910 · Museu Nacional d'Art de Catalunya



Isidre Nonell. Flores. Image credit: Isidre Nonell. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The title names a sitter, not a bunch of flowers. Her yellow-green blouse and striped shawl give broad brushmarks something definite to describe; the marks remain visible without dissolving the person. Set beside *Consuelo*, this portrait makes a useful distinction between concealing a face through posture and simplifying one through the handling of paint.

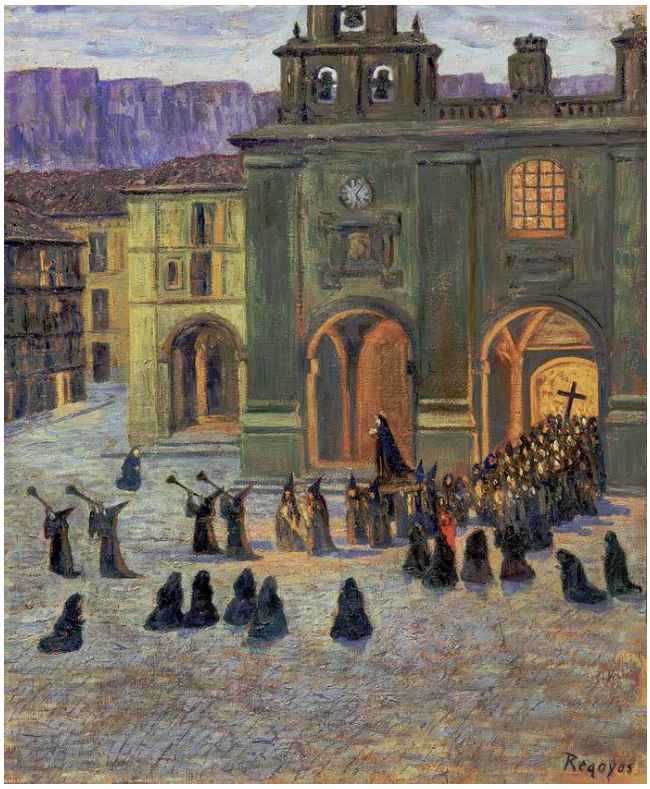
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 065619-000

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Good Friday at Dawn in Orduña

Darío de Regoyos

1903 · Museu Nacional d'Art de Catalunya



Darío de Regoyos. Good Friday Early Morning in Orduña. Image credit: Didier Descouens. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The procession shares the picture with the town's early light. Warm illuminated windows stand apart from cool buildings and dark clothes, making the time of day as important as the event. Rather than isolating a ritual against an empty background, Regoyos lets it become visible within the town that contains it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 065615-000

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The Holy Family

Muter Mela

c. 1909 · Museu Nacional d'Art de Catalunya



Mela Muter. Holy Family. Image credit: [MNAC]; Source credit: { https://www.museunacional.cat/ca/colleccio/santa-familia/mela-muter/011187-000}. Wikimedia Commons. CC BY-SA 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC BY-SA 4.0

The sacred title sits beside an ordinary-looking group of women and children. A nursing child and close-set bodies make care tangible without the elaborate setting of a ceremonial religious picture. That relation between name and appearance is worth holding open: the title proposes a frame for the scene, while the figures retain their everyday weight.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 011187-000

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Entrance to the Moulin de la Galette Park

Santiago Rusiñol

1891 · Museu Nacional d'Art de Catalunya



Santiago Rusinol. Entrance to the Park of the Moulin de la Galette. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The red wall and open gate promise entry, but the entertainment remains largely beyond reach. Distant figures offer only a small indication of what lies further along the path. Rusiñol paints the approach rather than the attraction itself, making a threshold and the expectation it creates sufficient subjects for a picture.

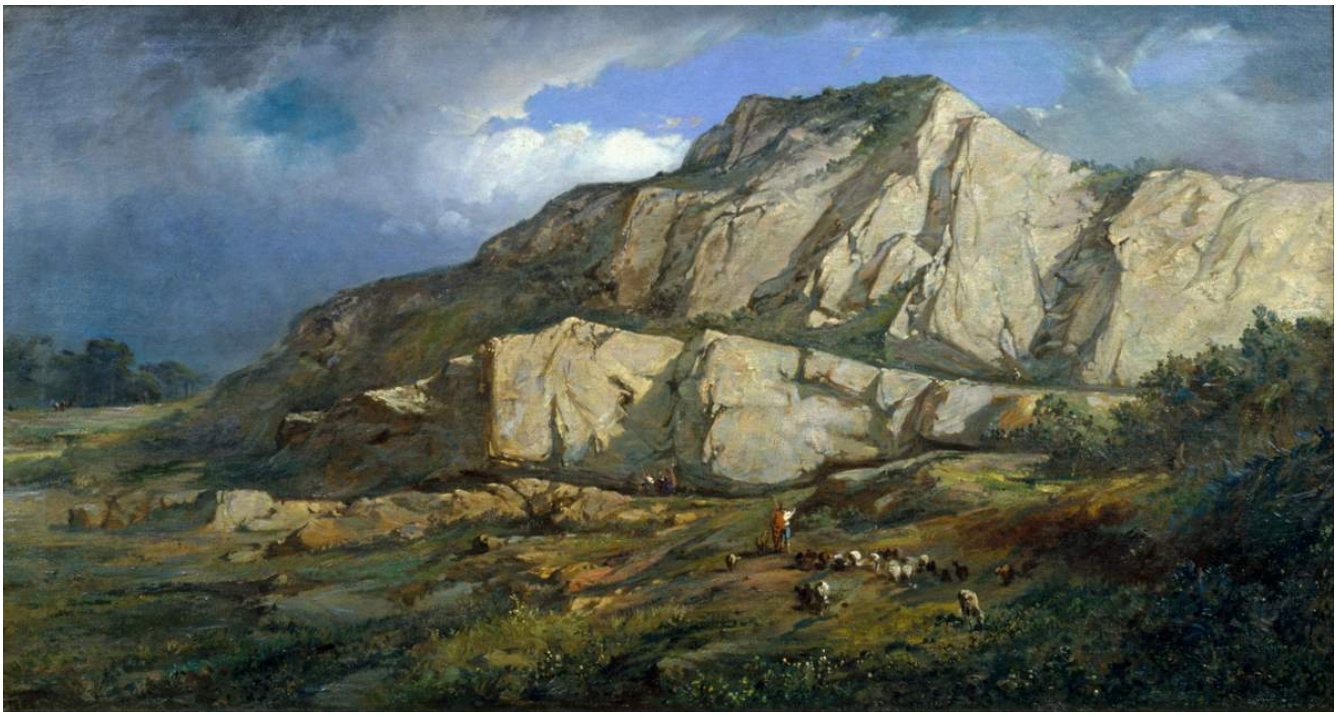
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 045267-000

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Landscape

Francesc Torrescassana Sallarés

1864 · Museu Nacional d’Art de Catalunya



Francesc Torrescassana Sallarés. Landscape. Image credit: Francesc Torrescassana (1845 - 1918) Born in Barcelona. Died in Barcelona. Details on Google Art Project. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Broken foreground stones give the eye a sequence of hard edges before it reaches the larger slopes. Plants occupy the gaps but do not soften the whole terrain into one green surface. The view can be read through differences of weight: solid rock close at hand, less distinct land beyond, and a sky that cannot be handled in the same way.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 010604-000

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Living Room Interior

Pere Tornè Esquius

1913 · Museu Nacional d’Art de Catalunya



Pere Tornè Esquius. Living Room Interior. Image credit: Didier Descouens. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The chairs, fireplace and patterned cloth are recognisable without an exhaustive account of their surfaces. Broad adjoining areas of colour give the room its arrangement. Compared with Rusiñol’s courtyards, the space is shallow, but it is not empty of character: distances between furnishings and the cloth’s red accent do the descriptive work.

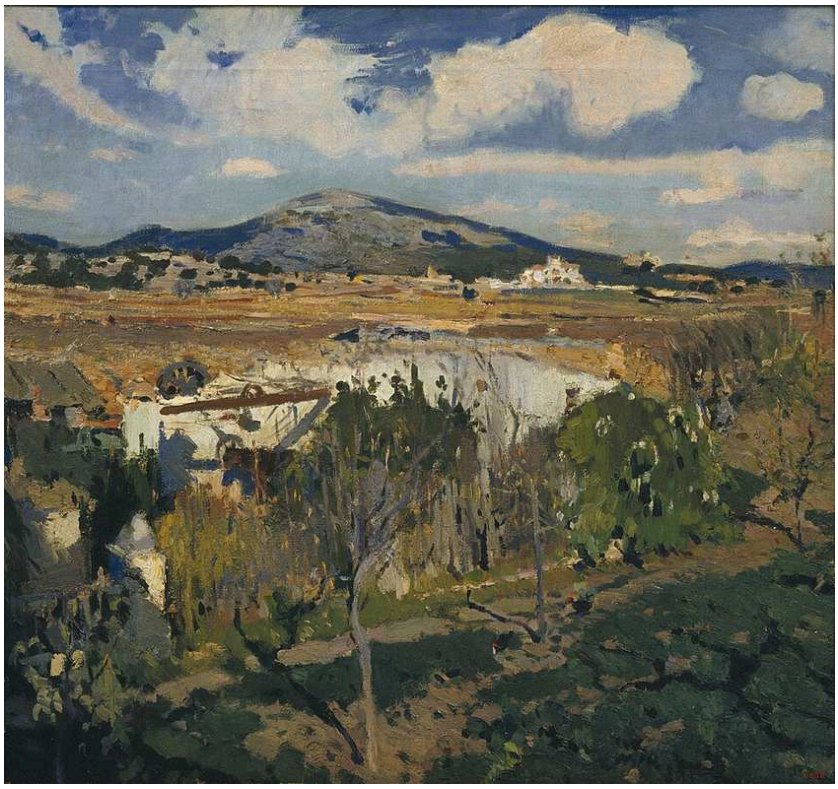
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 024668-000

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The Waterwheel at Onclet

Joaquín Mir Trinxet

1922 · Museu Nacional d'Art de Catalunya



Joaquín Mir Trinxet. Onclet Waterwheel. Image credit: Joaquín Mir Trinxet; https://www.museunacional.cat/en/colleccio/onclet-waterwheel/joaquim-mir/004632-000. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Joaquim_Mir_Onclet_Waterwheel_1922.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The waterworks structure establishes that this landscape is used, even though a person does not dominate it. Pale built surfaces stand among fields and trees rather than outside their order. The picture permits two readings at once: the distribution of light across land and the quieter evidence of work embedded in it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 004632-000

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Landscape

Joaquín Mir Trinxet

c. 1900 · Museu Nacional d’Art de Catalunya



Joaquín Mir Trinxet. Paisatge. Image credit: Joaquín Mir Trinxet. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Blue, green and yellow marks gather into vegetation without surrendering their identity as strokes. Warmer touches keep the foreground from becoming a single undifferentiated mass. Compare this with Torrescassana’s rocky *Landscape*: there, hard edges establish the ground; here, repeated touches and colour changes allow the terrain to emerge more gradually.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 207738-000

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Pancorbo: A Passing Train

Darío de Regoyos

1901 · Museu Nacional d'Art de Catalunya



Darío de Regoyos. Pancorbo: Passing Train. Image credit: Darío de Regoyos. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The train occupies only part of the valley, yet its steam introduces a conspicuously temporary shape. Village buildings, cliffs and slopes appear more settled around it. The contrast gives the railway a particular scale: substantial enough to interrupt the view, but small beside the terrain through which its movement has to pass.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 017453-000

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Peñalara

Jaume Morera i Galícia

c. 1891 · Museu Nacional d’Art de Catalunya



Jaume Morera i Galícia. Peñalara (Sierra de Guadarrama). Image credit: Didier Descouens. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The small figures offer a scale for the slopes, but the rough foreground also makes a claim on attention. It describes ground that cannot be crossed as easily as the eye crosses the distant view. That difference keeps the mountain from becoming merely a skyline: there is difficult terrain between the spectator’s position and the heights.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 024635-000

Follow one kind of space

A shorter reading can begin with the two cafés, move through the courtyard and garden, and finish with the passing train. Notice how often an opening or a gap organises the picture. This selection is not a room-by-room route; consult the museum’s current information for display availability.

Further reading

Impressionism: A Centenary Exhibition

Anne Dayez, Michel Hoog and Charles S. Moffett · Read online or download · English

This catalogue introduces the French painting debated and adapted by artists across Europe in the later nineteenth century. It provides context for the guide’s outdoor subjects without implying that every Catalan painter followed the same path.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12